

Appendix 2.

Catalogue of the LVP sites

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In this catalogue a selection of re-investigated excavations of villa sites in Limburg is presented (fig. 1). The excavations were carried out during approximately 170 years of archaeological research by the National Museum of Antiquities in Leiden. If functions could be attributed to rooms or other features observed, they are represented by colours according to fig. 2.

LVP-01 Mook-Plasmolen

- Villa type: villa urbana
- RMO 197, AM 1034
- Year discovered: 1863
- Researchers: Hermans 1863, RMO: Braat 1931, Holwerda 1932, ADC: Hazenberg 1999.
- References: Braat 1934, Hazenberg 1999, reconstruction: Peterse and Kocken 2000.
- Original field drawings present: yes, 1931.
- Visible on satellite image: yes.

Scenic location

The villa site lays halfway up the southern slope of a moraine, the Sint Jansberg, overlooking the Meuse valley in a westerly direction. The villa was built on an artificial terrace. This part of the moraine has been forested since at least the Middle Ages (as part of the 'Nederrijkswood').

History

The first finds of this villa were mentioned around 1863 by Barthold, baron van Verschuer, landowner and rentier, who at that time was reconstructing the three mills at Plasmolen he had just acquired. The terrain was scattered with building material, traditionally gratefully used by local residents for construction of buildings. Dr. C.R. Hermans, founder of the Provincial Society of Arts and Science in North Brabant, inspected the site and found fragments of intact walls, concrete flooring and roof tiles. No publications or drawings from the 19th century are known. Only 70 years later, in 1931, was the first scientific excavation carried out on behalf of the National Museum of Antiquities by Dr. W.C. Braat, the results of which were published in 1934 (Braat 1934, 4-13). The site heavily suffered from quarrying, forestation and erosion. Braat excavated 19 trenches and on the basis of the robber trenches he reconstructed a ground plan (fig. 5). A 20th trench was excavated on top of the Sint Jansberg where a small building with intact concrete floor was found. Due to limitations set by the

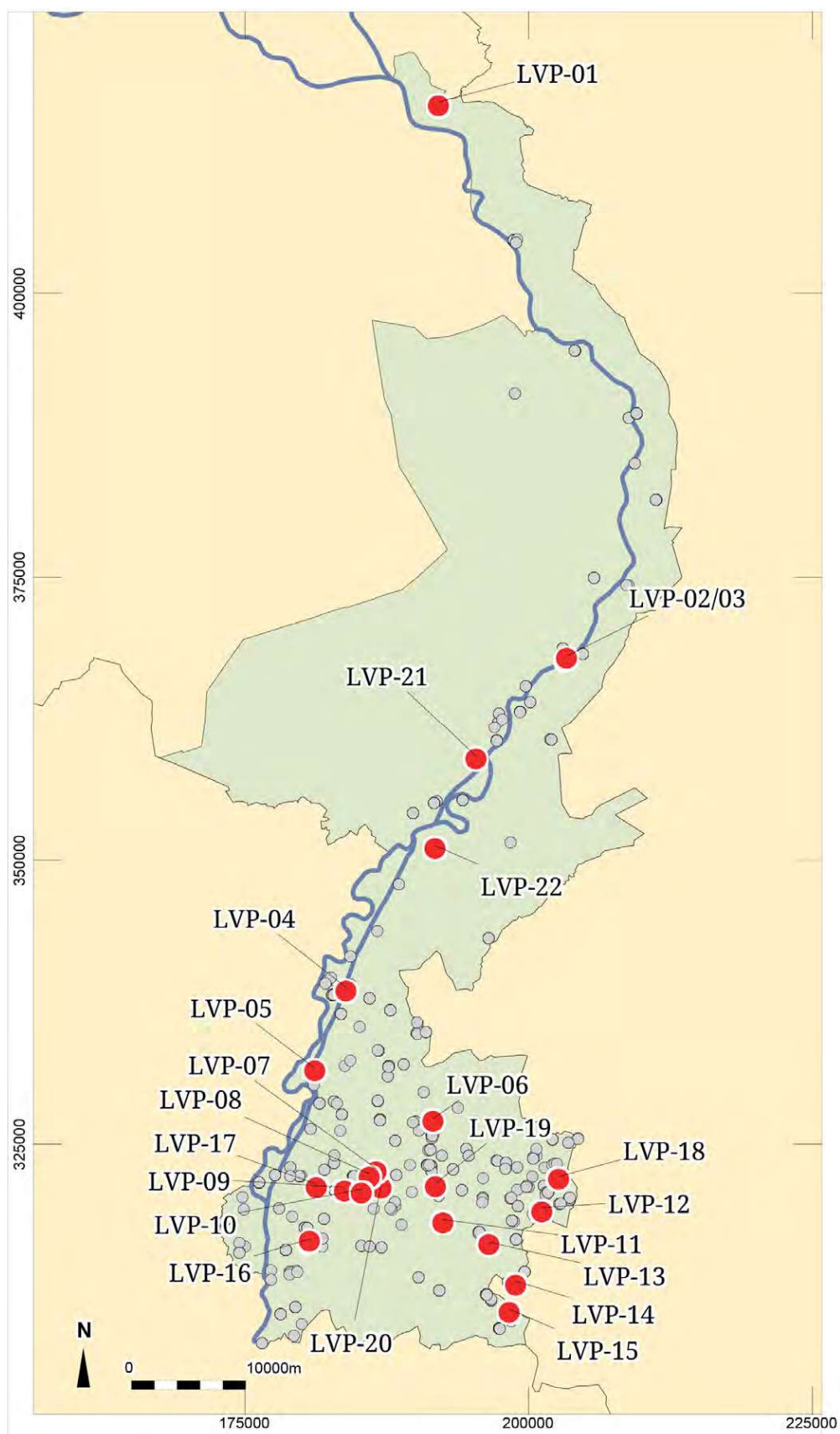


Fig. 1 Overview of the selection of villa sites. In grey, known villa sites registered in Archis.

Legend			
	Excavated		Bath facility
	Masonry/stone		Heating room
	Robber trenches		Building ceramics
	Heated rooms		Water well
	Cellar		Other features

Fig. 2 Used colours with functions in the drawings.

landowner, this building was not excavated further. Braat found hardly any intact structural remains of the main building, mostly only robber trenches, but presumably one room could be attributed to a cellar, on the basis of the depth of the remaining walls in room 8. In some rooms hypocaust tiles (*bessales*) were preserved on concrete sub floors. During WW II, the site was occupied by German soldiers who used the still open excavation trenches for a defensive position. Only 70 years later, in 1999, a second excavation took place (fig. 5). This was intended to establish the conservation and degradation of the in 1976 designated protected archaeological monument. The preservation was very poor but some hypocaust *pilae* were still preserved in place. Also a robber trench, which until then had remained unknown, was discovered at the eastside of the building. In 2000, a reconstruction of the villa was made by K. Peterse (Peterse and Kocken 2000). Braat referred in his publication to the robber trenches and in situ stone walls as the location of fundaments or walls, making no distinction between them. Peterse made his reconstruction based on a combination of his expertise on modern architectural practices, knowledge of Mediterranean architecture, the proportional building rules published by Vitruvius, the Roman foot (*Pes Monetalis*), and the excavation data. The villa, which can still be visited today, was partly reconstructed in 2006 on the basis of his research.

The building

Measurements follow the reconstruction of Peterse. The building measures approximately 20,80 × 83,20 m, built in a NE-SW orientation. At the westside a portico and presumably a main entrance was situated. At the east side a wall was built as a border in the terraced landscape. The layout of the building is symmetrical. In the centre of the building Peterse situated the reception room. There were no traces of a peristyle found. A connecting hallway between the two outer wings was heated. Both outer wings were also heated, in the north private rooms, in the south bath rooms. Peterse did not reconstruct a heating room. For probable functions of the other rooms

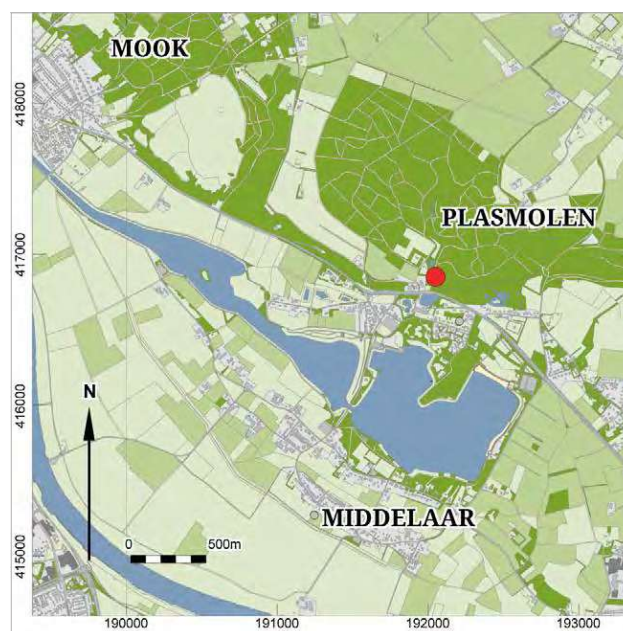


Fig. 3 Location of the villa at Plasmolen.

see fig. 4. Both Braat and Peterse reconstructed the height of the building using Vitruvius' proportion theory. Braat suggested that rooms 6 and 13 would have been open spaces or *atria* (fig. 4), which would have allowed light into the central parts of the building. Peterse on the other hand thought that windows above the portico/corridor-roofs would have fulfilled this purpose. Furthermore, he suggested that the narrow rooms 14 and 27 were used as staircases to reach an upper floor in both wings of the building.

Finds

At the time of the excavations in 1863 and 1934 it was not archaeological practice to document the locations of specific finds with precision. Nor was it practice to excavate rooms completely. Only enough data were gathered to make a reconstruction of the fundaments of the building and to date it roughly. On rare occasions a findspot of a coin or a special find like fragments of marble or wall painting are indicated, but no find numbers were being used. *E.g.* in room 30 fragments of wall painting in a floral motif were found in 1934. Many fragments of wall painting were found in 1999, scattered over the site. These have not been researched. This leaves us with an assemblage that represents the period of use only generally. Among the pottery, terra sigillata dates from the 2nd century, painted cups from the 2nd and 3rd centuries, amphorae (of which one comes from Campania) date to the 1st century. Other pottery derives from dolia, mortaria and jugs.